

Guest Speaker Summary: Financial Aid and Scholarships

Anthony Bettencourt's presentation covered how financial aid works at SJSU and how students can apply for and use it. He stated that financial aid is simply assistance provided to a student or parent to help fill the gap between the amount of money the family can contribute and what the college actually costs. Students can apply through FAFSA or the California Dream Act Application at caldreamact.org, both of which are free to submit an application for. The priority application deadline is March 2nd, and the Financial Aid Office reaches out to students via their MYSJSU portal, so it is important for students to periodically check their To-Do list for additional actions the school requests from them. Once the application is submitted, the evaluation process takes approximately 6 to 8 weeks. During the window, students may see a registration fee deferral on their account. This means that the application has been received and is being processed. When the evaluation is completed, students receive an award notification via their one. sjsu account, which they should read carefully for hidden fine print and then need to accept the financial aid for it to be disbursed into their account. The disbursement begins during the first week of the semester and is done on a weekly basis. Funds are sent electronically to the student account to cover any outstanding fees from the school, and any remaining balance is released to the student or the parent via a paper check or direct deposit (if applicable). The presentation outlined the categories of financial aid: federal aid and state aid, both available through the FAFSA and, for state aid, the Dream Act Application. Loans are also an optional form of financial aid, including subsidized and unsubsidized loans plus parent PLUS loans. For PLUS loans, the parents must apply separately at studentloans.gov. Federal work-study is also an opportunity to gain financial aid via employment and gain real work experience at the same time. Opportunities are posted during the summer for students to apply through sjsu.edu/career/center, though incoming students can not work during the summer and must wait until the Fall semester. There is also a special circumstances appeal where students can use their more recent tax information for the FAFSA and have their information reevaluated if their financial situation changes.

Another significant part of financial aid is the opportunity to gain scholarships. These are listed at sjsu.edu/faso/types-of-aid/scholarships. Applications for the 2027-28 school year open in the spring. He explained that different departments within the school are known to handle their own scholarships. Also, there are opportunities for external scholarships through outside companies and organizations (students must be careful and avoid scams). External scholarship funds take about 6 weeks to reach each student after the organization sends them to SJSU. Bettencourt spent extra time on the personal statements and the application process itself. He stressed the importance of personalizing your essay and avoiding the use of "AI slop." Common prompt questions include describing your personal strengths and weaknesses or explaining the importance of your major in today's work environment and society to encourage SJSU to support your efforts. Finally, he covered what happens after a student wins a scholarship: winners are typically notified in the fall semester and should routinely check their MySJSU portal as well as any conditions of acceptance, such as required ceremonies or tasks. These scholarship funds are added to your overall financial aid package, including grants and work-study opportunities.

For questions, the Financial Aid Office offers a live chat at sjsu.edu/fafsa from 10am-3pm on weekdays, a phone line at 408-283-7500 from 9am-4pm, virtual appointments on Fridays from 10 am-3pm, email support at fao@sjsu.edu, and walk-in hours from 8am-5pm Monday-Friday.